

Counseling Theory Reflective Summary

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When I began my counseling coursework, I knew that empathy and support mattered, but I had not yet developed a clear sense of how theory would guide my work. Writing my Integrative Theory assignment helped me connect my values and experiences with reality therapy, person-centered therapy, and existential therapy. I learned that counseling is not about using one approach for every person; it is about understanding each client's needs, strengths, culture, and goals and responding intentionally. Reflecting on my experience as a first-generation immigrant from Mexico also clarified why creating a safe, nonjudgmental space is so important to me. I have grown from simply wanting to help others into developing a professional identity grounded in empathy, accountability, authenticity, healthy boundaries, and respect for each client's voice.

My Literature Review deepened my understanding of multicultural counseling by teaching me to look beyond individual symptoms. I learned how colonization, intergenerational trauma, racism, immigration experiences, poverty, and other systems can affect mental health. Concepts such as *Nepantla* and culturally meaningful expressions like *nervios* showed me that clients may understand and communicate distress in ways that Western counseling models can miss. This made me more aware of the harm counselors can cause when they assume one worldview fits everyone. I have grown in cultural humility by learning to listen for a client's language, history, community, and way of making meaning. I now understand that effective counseling also involves advocacy, honoring cultural strengths, and continually examining my own biases rather than seeing myself as the expert on someone else's experience.

My Skill Development Self-Assessment showed me that becoming a counselor requires practice, honest reflection, and openness to feedback. During role-play, I became more confident using open-ended questions, paraphrasing, door openers, and minimal encouragers, while recognizing skills I still needed to strengthen. At first, I was nervous about reflecting feelings incorrectly and uncomfortable with silence, and I sometimes noticed my own opinions wanting to enter the session. Supervision taught me that it is better to respond thoughtfully and remain open to correction than to avoid a client's emotions. I also learned how small choices in tone or wording can unintentionally feel dismissive. Since the beginning of my coursework, I have become more intentional about listening to understand instead of listening to respond. I know my skills will continue developing, but I now approach that process with greater patience, self-awareness, and willingness to learn.